

Report 2

What this is: a report written by the same research agent on 13 September 2026, from the request below. The request is the kind an interview produces: it says who is travelling, from where, on which dates, what the report is for, which sources to use and how to judge it.

Plan a budget trip to Rome for two students flying from Larnaca, first time in Rome, 18 to 22 December 2026 (4 nights). Budget: 600 euros each for everything, flights included. We sleep in a hostel.

What the report is for: to decide which days to fly and whether to book now or wait.

Format: a day-by-day plan, and every cost in one table (flights, hostel, transport, food, tickets), per person and total.

Sources: prices from the airlines' and the museums' own sites, not from blogs. Check opening days and hours for the week before Christmas.

Success criteria: every price with its source and the date you saw it. Say plainly what you could not find.

Rome on a budget, 18–22 December 2026: research report

Two students, flying from Larnaca, first time in Rome, sleeping in a hostel, target €600 each for everything including flights. Research done and all prices checked on **13 September 2026**. Every price below states its source and is dated. Where I could not get a confirmed number, that is stated plainly rather than guessed.

The headline finding: your dates don't match the flight schedule

18 December 2026 is a **Friday**. 22 December 2026 is a **Tuesday**. I checked every airline that flies Larnaca (LCA)–Rome Fiumicino (FCO) direct, and none of them fly on Tuesdays:

Airline	Days it flies LCA–FCO	Source
Cyprus Airways	Monday, Friday (route launches 11 Dec 2026, year-round)	Cyprus Airways route announcement, Cyprus Mail, 19 Aug 2026
Wizz Air (Wizz Air Malta)	Monday, Friday (reported)	Could not confirm on wizzair.com itself – see gaps below
ITA Airways	Wednesday, Friday, Sunday	Reported by aggregators; could not load ita-airways.com directly (403 error) to confirm on the airline's own site
Aegean Airlines	Unclear – sources conflict (2–3x/week)	flights.aegeanair.com does not publish a weekly timetable, only fares

Friday 18 December is well served – three carriers plausibly fly that day. **Tuesday 22 December is not served by any confirmed carrier**. This is the key decision for your trip:

- **Option A (recommended): fly out Fri 18 Dec, back Mon 21 Dec – 3 nights.** Matches Wizz Air's and Cyprus Airways' Monday/Friday pattern on both legs, and costs one less hostel night.
- **Option B: fly out Fri 18 Dec, back Wed 23 Dec – 5 nights.** Matches ITA Airways' Friday/Wednesday pattern, gives you a full extra day, costs one more hostel night and day of

food.

- **Option C: keep your exact 18–22 Dec dates.** Possible only if Aegean turns out to operate a Tuesday flight (unconfirmed) or by accepting a one-stop itinerary (e.g., via Athens), which I did not price.

The day-by-day plan below follows your original Fri–Tue request (4 nights), but you should re-check this against Option A/B before booking, since your requested return day may not exist as a direct flight.

Book now or wait?

- **Cyprus Airways** is a brand-new route (announced 19 Aug 2026, launching 11 Dec 2026). On its own fare page, cyprusairways.com/en/flights-from-larnaka-to-italy (checked 13 Sep 2026), the cheapest round trip shown is **"from €119"**, but the only dated itineraries it displays are in January–February 2027 — **December 2026 fares are not yet loaded into their search widget**, three months before the launch. Worth checking back every few weeks; introductory fares on new routes are often the cheapest they'll be, but there's no guarantee they'll appear for your exact dates soon.
- **Aegean's own site**, flights.aegeanair.com (checked 13 Sep 2026), shows a December 2026 low-fare-calendar floor of **"from €143" one-way LCA→FCO** and, on the [reverse route page](#), **"from €151" one-way FCO→LCA**. These are teaser "from" prices for the cheapest day that month, not a quote for your specific dates, and the site explicitly warns fares are "collected within the last 48hrs and may no longer be available."
- The week before Christmas is peak demand for anyone flying home for the holidays out of Cyprus, so the realistic fare is likely above these floor prices, not below them.
- **My recommendation: book now rather than wait**, once you've settled on Option A or B above — check all three airlines directly for the exact day-pair you choose, since the confirmed direct-flight days are a harder constraint than the price.

What I could not get from the airlines' own sites

Per your instruction to use airline sites rather than blogs, I tried each carrier's own booking engine directly. Wizz Air (wizzair.com) returned an HTTP 405 error to automated fetching, and ITA Airways (ita-airways.com) returned HTTP 403 — both block the tool I used to read pages, so **I could not confirm a euro price on either airline's own site for your dates**. You will need to check wizzair.com and ita-airways.com yourselves for a live quote. The only airline-sourced numbers I obtained are Aegean's and Cyprus Airways' "from" prices above.

Day-by-day plan (as requested: Fri 18 – Tue 22 Dec)

Day 1 – Friday 18 December (arrival). Fly LCA→FCO. Train (Leonardo Express, 32 min) or regional FL1 train into Rome, check into the hostel near Termini, short walk to Piazza della Repubblica, simple dinner nearby. Exact arrival time depends on which flight you book — none of the schedules I found confirm times for December 2026.

Day 2 – Saturday 19 December – Vatican day. Vatican Museums and Sistine Chapel open 8:00–20:00 (last entry 18:00) Monday–Saturday; book the earliest online slot to beat the queue. Afterward, St.

Peter's Basilica (free) and St. Peter's Square. Evening: cross towards Piazza Navona, dinner in the centro storico or Trastevere.

Day 3 – Sunday 20 December – Ancient Rome day. Important: the **Vatican Museums are closed on Sundays** except the last Sunday of the month – and December's last Sunday is 27 Dec, after you've left – confirmed on the [Vatican Museums' own opening-hours page](#), checked 13 Sep 2026. So Sunday is the day to do the Colosseum, Roman Forum and Palatine Hill instead – the Colosseum park is open every day of the year except 25 Dec and 1 Jan, per [colosseo.it's official hours page](#), checked 13 Sep 2026 (winter hours: opens 8:30, last admission 15:30, closes 16:30). Afternoon: Pantheon (open daily 9:00–19:00, last entry 18:30, per the official [cultura.gov.it Pantheon page](#), checked 13 Sep 2026), then Trevi Fountain, Spanish Steps, Piazza Navona – all free, all walkable in a loop. Evening in Trastevere.

Day 4 – Monday 21 December – flex day. Catch anything missed (a second Vatican pass if Saturday was rushed, Castel Sant'Angelo, Campo de' Fiori market, Trastevere by daylight, Testaccio). If you take Option A above, this is your flight-home day instead.

Day 5 – Tuesday 22 December (departure, as requested). Morning at leisure, then train to FCO. Flag again: no carrier was confirmed to fly this route on a Tuesday – see the flights section above before locking this in.

Practical note on timing: the Colosseum requires a compulsory timed-entry reservation that **only opens 30 days before your visit date** (stated on [colosseo.it](#)) – so for an 18–22 Dec visit, you cannot book it yet as of 13 Sep 2026; the window opens roughly mid-to-late November 2026. Various (non-official) ticket resale/guide sites report the Vatican Museums release tickets 60 days ahead, which would put that window at roughly mid-to-late October 2026 – I could not confirm this "60 days" figure on museivaticani.va itself, so treat it as unverified.

Cost table

Prices are full/adult rate unless noted; sources and check-date follow each line.

Item	Per person	For two	Source (checked 13 Sep 2026)
Flights, LCA↔FCO round trip	~€294 (floor estimate – see caveats)	~€588	Aegean's own fare pages – "from €143" one-way out + "from €151" one-way back. Not a confirmed quote for your exact dates ; Wizz Air and ITA Airways prices could not be retrieved (see "What I could not get" above); Cyprus Airways has no December 2026 fares live yet. Treat this line as the single biggest source of uncertainty in the budget.
Hostel, 4 nights, mixed dorm bed	~€84	~€168	YellowSquare Rome via Hostelworld listing (6-bed mixed ensuite dorm, ~€21/night) – an aggregator estimate, not a locked quote for 18–22 Dec 2026 (the live booking calendar is JavaScript-based and I could not query it directly for your exact dates)
City tax (cash on arrival, typical Rome hostel)	~€14	~€28	Reported city-tax rate (~€3.50/person/night) at comparable hostels via Hostelworld/Booking.com listings – confirm the exact amount at check-in

Item	Per person	For two	Source (checked 13 Sep 2026)
Transport: 2× Leonardo Express (airport–Termini)	€28	€56	Trenitalia via Aeroporti di Roma's official transfer page – €14 each way, 32 minutes
Transport: city buses/metro (BIT tickets + a day pass)	~€17	~€34	ATAC's official fares page – single ride (100 min) €1.50; ROMA24H pass €8.50
Museum/site tickets: Colosseum + Forum + Palatine	€18	€36	colosseo.it official ticket page – full price. EU citizens aged 18 up to their 25th birthday pay €2 on the same page – worth checking if this applies to you
Museum/site tickets: Vatican Museums + Sistine Chapel	€25	€50	museivaticani.va official prices page – €20 full price + mandatory €5 online booking fee for skip-the-line entry; a €10 "reduced/student" rate exists (+€5 booking fee = €15) – eligibility criteria weren't fully spelled out on the page I could read, confirm at booking
Museum/site tickets: Pantheon	€7	€14	cultura.gov.it official Pantheon page – full price; EU citizens 18–25 pay €2
Food (4.5 days: breakfast/lunch/dinner + snacks, budget style)	~€110	~€220	Estimated from Numbeo's Rome cost-of-living data (checked 13 Sep 2026): inexpensive restaurant meal ≈ €15, fast-food combo ≈ €10; no official source exists for food, this is a planning estimate only
Total	~€597	~€1,194	

This lands right at the €600/person ceiling – and only because the flight line uses the lowest floor price found, not a confirmed fare. If real fares for your chosen dates come in even €30–50 higher per person (plausible for the week before Christmas), you are over budget and will need to trim the hostel (cheaper dorm bed size), skip the Vatican's paid online-booking fee (pay €20 at the door and risk a queue), or use the EU-reduced ticket prices where eligible.

Money-saving check I ran for you: is the Roma Pass worth it?

No, not for this itinerary. The 72-hour Roma Pass costs **€62.90** ([official price, museiincomuneroma.it](#), checked 13 Sep 2026) and includes 72 hours of transport plus discounted (not free) entry to the Colosseum at €11.50 (per [colosseo.it](#)) – and it does **not** cover the Vatican Museums at all. Buying a Colosseum ticket (€18) plus a 72-hour ATAC transport pass (€22) separately costs €40, i.e. about €23 less per person than the Roma Pass, for this two-museum, walking-heavy itinerary.

What I could not find – stated plainly

- **No confirmed euro price from Wizz Air's or ITA Airways' own websites** for any date – both blocked automated access (405 and 403 errors respectively). You must check these two directly.
- **No fare from any airline for the exact 18 Dec–22 Dec date pair**, because no carrier appears to operate a Tuesday flight on this route at all (see above).
- **No live, date-specific hostel quote.** Hostel booking engines (Hostelworld, the hostels' own sites) are JavaScript applications my tool cannot query with real dates; the hostel prices above are

aggregator estimates, not confirmed bookings.

- **The Vatican's "60 days advance booking" rule** is reported by third-party ticket guides but I could not verify it on museivaticani.va itself.
- I did not research or price Galleria Borghese (requires reservation weeks in advance and is a further trip from the centre) or Castel Sant'Angelo, since they didn't fit a tight 3–4 day budget itinerary – flag if you want these priced too.